

PEOPLES OF EUROPE

EUROPE IS A CROWDED CONTINENT. It is the second smallest of the continents by area, yet it has the third highest population. As a result, population densities are very high, and most Europeans live in cities. Europe is also crowded with countries – more than 40 different nations jostle for position on the continent. Conflicts between these countries have often erupted into war – two world wars have started on European soils in the last 100 years. Yet, despite these problems, Europe is by and large a rich continent, and many European countries are among the wealthiest in the world. Some pockets of poverty exist, but in general the population enjoys a high standard of living compared to most other parts of the world. Much of this wealth has come as a result of industrial growth, and because of the large colonial empires established by many European countries in Africa, Asia, and the Americas.

Population: approximately 774,000,000 people
Number of countries: 43



EUROPEAN CITIES

A large proportion of Europeans live in cities. The most densely populated part of Europe lies in the west and forms a belt that stretches more or less continuously from southeastern Britain, through northern France, Belgium, the Netherlands, and into Germany. In these densely populated areas, individual cities can merge into one another, forming what are known as conurbations. The largest of these is in the German industrial region known as the Ruhr. By contrast, in eastern Europe a greater proportion of the population lives in country areas.

Largest country:

The Russian Federation straddles northern Europe and Asia (see page 138) and its European part covers 1,527,341 sq miles (3,955,818 sq km).

Least densely populated country: Iceland, 7 people per sq mile (3 per sq km)

- KEY**
- 1 NETHERLANDS
 - 2 BELGIUM
 - 3 LUXEMBOURG
 - 4 SWITZERLAND
 - 5 LIECHTENSTEIN
 - 6 MOLDOVA
 - 7 ANDORRA
 - 8 MONACO
 - 9 SAN MARINO
 - 10 VATICAN CITY
 - 11 SLOVENIA
 - 12 CROATIA
 - 13 BOSNIA AND HERZEGOVINA
 - 14 SERBIA
 - 15 MONTENEGRO
 - 16 KOSOVO (disputed)
 - 17 ALBANIA
 - 18 MACEDONIA

Most densely populated country: Monaco, 42,840 people per sq mile (16,477 per sq km)

Smallest country: Vatican City, 0.17 sq miles (0.44 sq km)

POPULATION DENSITY

Over 774 million Europeans are crammed into an area little more than the size of Australia. As a result, European countries have some of the highest population densities in the world. In the Netherlands, for example, there are 1,229 people per sq mile (475 per sq km). Population densities in eastern Europe are lower, but even these are above the world average.

Population density chart

The figures on the chart show the number of people per sq mile (per sq km). Comparisons outside Europe are also included.

